



of Arles in the 5th and 6th centuries CE both condemned *charaktêres* as demonic, but such views did not stop people from inscribing them on amulets, or passing them on in magical texts. *Charaktêres* also appeared alongside Christian words and symbols in amulets from, for example, medieval Byzantium. In early medieval Arabic texts, they were linked to constellations.

Angelic alphabets survived long beyond the medieval period, and Jewish *Karaqtiraya* were studied by the famous 16th-century German occultist Cornelius Agrippa. Agrippa later disclaimed his works on magic as youthful

folly, but various angelic alphabets are attributed to him, including the so-called celestial alphabet; the *Malachim* (from the Hebrew word *mal'akh* for “angels” or “messengers”); and the *Transitus Fluvii* (from the Latin for “crossing the river”). All three appear to have been influenced by *Karaqtiraya*. Also in the 16th century, the English alchemist John Dee along with his associate Edward Kelley created a celestial alphabet, which they claimed was revealed to them by angelic spirits that appeared in visions.

▲ Crossing cultures

Magic signs and symbols were borrowed and re-borrowed across cultures, as this 10th- or 11th-century Byzantine amulet shows, with its *charaktêres*, Seal of Solomon, and ancient Greek text.